

has on our finances. Let me use my own environment both growing up and today to explain.

I have the advantage of having a dad who is an accountant. While there were very few financial discussions growing up, he was someone I could trust to ask financial questions of during my twenties and thirties because I knew he was financially literate. More than that, because he surprised us all by retiring comfortably in his early fifties, it seemed he wasn't only financially literate, he was also financially smart.

I also had the advantage of grandparents who modelled a financial environment I like to call 'healthy frugality'. My maternal grandparents were able to save money on the pension, had a freezer stocked with homemade food and believed the use-by dates on food were made up by marketers to sell you more and shouldn't be taken at face value. These same grandparents went on annual five-month pilgrimages in their caravan to warmer climates. My grandma ran her own cafe during the war (she was an amazing cook) and the proceeds helped her and my grandpop to purchase a modest family home.

My paternal nana, meanwhile, had an obsession with clothes (something I have inherited), but as a single mum she couldn't afford to indulge this passion in retail stores. So, she used to take me second-hand shopping from an early age and taught me the importance of mending and tailoring. She taught me that it's possible to have style on any budget and to wear what you love every day.

The consequence of this history is that today I have established a Money Environment where, if I need to, I know I can run financial scenarios past my dad, but I also have used the influence of my grandparents by adopting their attitude of healthy frugality with my daily spending habits. By being especially frugal with my day-to-day spending it means I'm not at risk financially when I do binge spend on things I love—I'm not going to lie, often that's shoes. By understanding my Money Story and setting up my Money Environment in this way, it now means I can choose to overspend on certain things because of my thrifty daily spending. This frugality extends to everything from how much alcohol I drink to making batches of frozen meals and lunches on the weekend, ignoring best-before dates on food packaging, avoiding tolls when I'm driving if possible, enjoying 'staycations' rather than going away on expensive holidays, timing